



Too close to work together? Identity conflicts induced by coworker friendships in cyberspace

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ABSTRACT

The meteoric rise in the popularity of social networking sites (SNSs) has connected many employees with their contacts from work. However, clashes are catalyzed when individuals' professional identities collide with their social ones. This paper aims to explore hotel employees' identity conflicts stemming from cross-boundary friendships. Building on cognitive dissonance theory and conservation of resources theory, a multilevel model is proposed to examine how befriending colleagues on SNSs induces unfavorable workplace consequences through the mediation effect of identity conflict. The model further scrutinizes whether task interdependence intensifies this negative spillover. This study probes a novel identity issue aroused by SNS interactions in a professional context and advances research on interpersonal dynamics in organizations. It also provides new insights on the role of team-level situational factors. The results generate managerial implications for hotels and employees, suggesting that both groups should be better prepared for possible dilemmas embedded in cross-boundary relationships.

1. Introduction

Employees spend one third of their time per day in close proximity to their coworkers, and maybe more nowadays, given the rising trend of befriending work colleagues on social networking sites (SNSs) such as Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter. The surging interest in and use of SNSs have blurred the boundaries between personal and professional domains, connecting more than two thirds of employees with colleagues on the Internet (Igloo, 2018). Empirical studies have documented positive spillovers from cyberspace to the workplace, such as more workplace fun, entrenched interpersonal relationships, enhanced coworker support, improved employee identification, increased embeddedness, and higher satisfaction with the job (Yang, 2020a; Yang and Wong, 2020). However, such online friendships may also backfire. Despite concerns about privacy and work-life balance that have been widely discussed in previous literature (e.g., Abril et al., 2012; Bucher et al., 2013; van Zoonen et al., 2016), there exists a potential risk of identity conflict in the workplace—of being “too close to work together” (Yang and Wong, 2020, p. 8). That is, intimacy on SNSs may induce unnecessary trouble in a work context. Such interactions on SNSs may change how individuals view their colleagues. As Del Bosque (2013) noted,

about one half of the employees surveyed agreed that SNSs reshaped their perceptions of the identity of their colleagues, of which 32% of changes were positive and 68% were negative or mixed. Befriending colleagues on SNSs may also generate the “greatest potential for conflict due to mix of social & professional self-presentation” (Archer-Brown et al., 2018, p. 76). Despite its importance, identity conflict across the workplace and SNSs is as yet uncharted territory that has not been empirically scrutinized.

Employees' self-definitions can be multi-faceted. Their intra-unit identity conflicts arise when misalignment exists in values, beliefs, and norms as a result of the collision of their multiple identities, in particular between work and non-work roles (Horton et al., 2014). Such inconsistencies are referred to as “cognitive dissonance” (cognitive dissonance theory: Festinger, 1957). For instance, a female manager often finds her identity as a woman and her identity as a leader incompatible. The former is associated with communal behaviors and feminine traits such as warmth, caring, and cooperation, while the latter is expected to be assertive, competitive, and determined—the archetypal figure of the male (Karelai and Guillén, 2014). With these identity conflicts in the workplace, disamenity may spill over and escalate.

Similar clashes have been catalyzed when individuals' professional

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